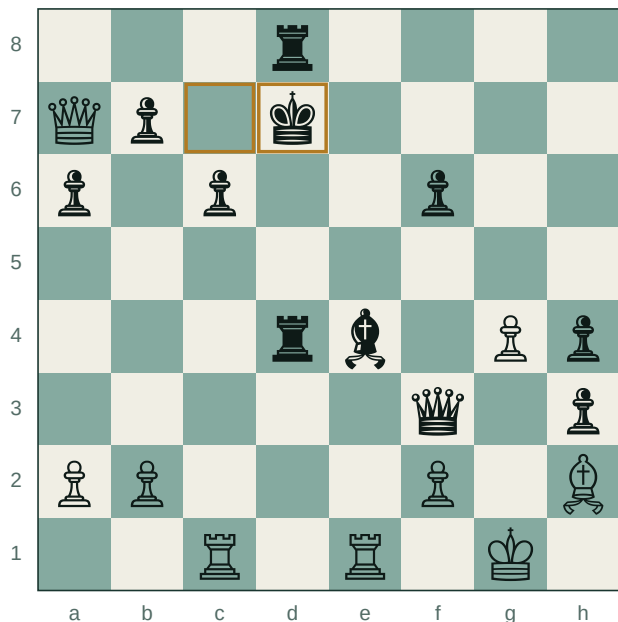


Loose-piece tactics: White, move 33

Loose-piece tactics

White to move



Previous move: 32...Kd7. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

33. Qxd4+ Bd5 34. Qxd5+

33.Qxd4+ Check restricts Black to 5 legal replies here. From d4 it attacks king on d7 and bishop on e4. Recorded reply: **33...Bd5**.

34.Qxd5+ Check restricts Black to 3 legal replies here. From d5 it attacks king on d7 and queen on f3.

At the end, nominal material is White 26 / Black 20 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +8. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +8: the balance goes from -2 to +6. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A piece may appear hanging because its defender is indirect: taking it might allow mate, a fork, or a stronger capture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

An undefended or tactically undefendable piece can turn an ordinary position into a combination. The first task is to distinguish a truly free capture from a poisoned one.

HOW TO LOOK

List the loose enemy pieces and check whether a forcing move can expose or attack more than one of them.

The defending king is on d7. Absolute pin: pawn on b7.